



King of Thieves

Zeptolab, the creators of Cut The Rope are going to launch King of Thieves - a new platformer with multiplayer capabilities. http://dgit.in/King_TH



DirectX 12 better?

Microsoft recently claimed that the upcoming DirectX 12 will perform almost 50% better than DirectX 11. <http://dgit.in/DX12Better>

Space Age

can carry one pilot, a ticketed passenger and a payload above an altitude of 100 km. The concept has been discussed since 2003, when the organisation announced a two-person suborbital spaceplane called Xerus. But concrete reports are rare. Lynx, which was announced on March 26, 2008, planned an operational vehicle within two years. But the building process of the Lynx Mark I didn't commence till September 2013. Currently, we hear that fabrication and assembly of the Lynx Mark I is underway. The first flight testing of Mark I will take place sometime this year and only later will the Mark II's production be underway. We have our fingers crossed for this one!

SPACING OUT IN 2015

2015 will also be a crucial year for SpaceShip Two, especially after the disastrous flight testing last year. The Spaceship Two VSS Enterprise crashed due to an in-flight break-up during a powered flight test on October 31, 2014 and the accident is still under investigation. The test flights are scheduled to restart again this year with the second Spaceship Two spacecraft. It has a capacity for carrying six passengers and two crew members. Since the announcement of Virgin Galactic's commercial space travel service, it has received more than 400 paid passengers, each of which was snagged by paying an astronomical sum of 250,000 USD! Once the service is operational, passengers can go on a trip to space that will last for two and a half hours, though only a few minutes of the flight time would actually be spent in outer space.

The New Shepard spacecraft by Blue Origin is yet another vehicle that will take astronauts to space on suborbital jour-



After the horrific crash of SpaceShip Two in 2014, all eyes are on flight tests of SpaceShip Two VSS Voyager this year

neys. This spacecraft has a crew capsule that can carry three or more astronauts and would be launched by a separate rocket powered Propulsion Module. After launch, the crew capsule would coast along the edge of space and get a ringside view of the Earth. The New Shepard also has researchers excited, as they can now run experiments in space or a microgravity environment. The Blue Origin team ran the first test of the suborbital crew capsule escape system in 2012 with positive results. But from then on, little progress has been seen.

JUST AROUND THE CORNER

Sierra Nevada Corporation (SNC) space systems' Dream Chaser spacecraft has also been under production. This reusable, crewed, suborbital and orbital space plane can carry up to seven people and would be launched on the Atlas V rocket. The cutting edge design has an in-built launch escape system and the spacecraft can even fly autonomously. This promising spacecraft lands horizontally, much like an airplane, unlike other spacecrafts that require a parachute-aided water landing.

The first free-flight of the Dream Chaser took place on 26 October 2013 and the spacecraft flew along the correct flight path before crash landing. The initial orbital test flight of this spacecraft will take place in 2016.

INDIA'S LEAP INTO SPACE

As the race to create the ultimate reusable space vehicle heats up, India isn't content to just sit and watch. After the very successful Mangalyaan launch, the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) had recently announced that they would fly a reusable launch vehicle (RLV) in March. This technology demonstration could be the first step towards grappling with one of the biggest challenges of space commute, viz, building reusable space vehicles. The reusable vehicle will be deployed from Sriharikota and will fly for a short time before its launch and subsequent descent. The vehicle would waterland since India lacks a runway that is long enough. India currently spends 300 cr INR for satellite launches and using reusable space vehicles is sure to cut costs tenfold.

BEYOND THE BLIMP

The future of reusable space vehicles seems obscure, much like the idea itself. While many organisations are looking for a sustainable option, the high costs involved with creating and testing these spacecrafts and the fact that the success rate has been incredibly low are deterring many from venturing into this realm. But the way forward, especially when it comes to commercial space travel, lies with reusable space vehicles. But until one such model is successfully launched, our dreams of space travel may remain just that. **d**



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